'This is not India or America. Indians should go out [of Afghanistan]', said the message in crisp English.[5] Pinned to the almost decapitated body of Maniappan Raman Kutty, the Taliban had delivered India with a 48-hour ultimatum to halt work on the Zaranj-Delaram highway and withdraw all Border Roads Organisation (BRO) personnel. A truck driver from Kerala working with the BRO (that was building the highway in Nimroz), Kutty was kidnapped on 19 November 2005, along with three others, and, as promised by the abductors, killed on 21 November. India had refused to budge under pressure.[6] Still, the promptness with which the Taliban killed Kutty was puzzling. It was unusual that the Taliban would demand the shutting of an Indian infrastructural project without allowing scope for negotiations. Even though the ultimatum was extended by 24-hours, the unreasonable demand did not change.

Within an hour of the kidnapping, India's ambassador to Kabul, Rakesh Sood, established a channel with Karzai and the Afghan national security advisor Zalmai Rassoul, and called upon his American, Iranian, and Italian counterparts seeking support. Sood also reached out to Sigbatullah Mojaddedi, former president and head of the reconciliation commission who had contacts with moderate Taliban figures, P. S. Gailani, head of the Qadari sect and a prominent religious leader, and Arif Moorjai, a tribal chief and former minister of tribal affairs, in the hope that they would be able to make contact with the kidnappers. Nothing came out of it. In a last-ditch effort India opened an informal channel with Pakistan asking for help (not a surprising development given the ongoing composite dialogue between the two countries since January 2004). Nothing emerged from that either. Pakistan flatly denied that it had any links with the Taliban since its ouster in 2001. From that moment on, instead of preparing a negotiations team or finding the kidnappers, India directed all its efforts towards securing Kutty's release (and failed).[7] Four days after Kutty's death, the MEA's joint secretary on the Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran desk, Dilip Sinha, informed Robert O. Blake, the US political counselor in New Delhi, that blaming Pakistan for Kutty's murder was 'entirely media speculation', and India will not stop its developmental work in the country.[8] American diplomats were worried that India might pull the plug on its aid to Afghanistan at a time when the US itself had